

"A developing country like India, where the service industry is the base of the economy, is in a better position to benefit from the open source ecosystem. Open source will be leapfrogging to bigger and more core areas like transportation, smart cities, agriculture and renewable energy at a later stage," says Pavel Naiya, senior research analyst, Counterpoint Research.

Pankaj Prasad, principal research analyst, Gartner, also sees the growth in various open source developments across India. "Open source is spreading widely, and the spectrum of open source is expanding and pointing towards growth," he says. "There are vendors who are leveraging open source and being very innovative," Prasad adds.

Soon to surpass growth records of developed markets

Open source developments in India are already growing unprecedentedly. And now, the Indian region aims to surpass the open source activities of some major developed markets like the US and UK.

Experts consider it as an uphill task to imitate a developed model. However, there is a need to bring a localisation flavour to move ahead triumphantly. "India is at an early stage of open source development, and it will be an uphill task to build a similar ecosystem like what exists in the US," Naiya of Counterpoint Research says. "The target should not be to compete against any country or ecosystem. Rather, the focus should be to develop local solutions solving local problems, which will eventually be a part of global open source projects serving communities for the betterment of everyone," he adds.

Prasad of Gartner believes that the lag in the growth of open source developments can be overcome with faster adoption of evolving technologies in the Indian market. "Open source is going hand-in-hand with evolving technologies. Thus, we need to take a look at both aspects to reach the growth levels of matured markets," says Prasad.

Wipro's Aitken thinks that despite the slow adoption of open source in India compared to major European and US regions, it has already made 'huge strides' in the recent past. "We see that pace only increasing," Aitken says, adding, "With India's focus on becoming a world-class software development country, I believe it will soon become one of the leaders in the open source ecosystem."

Enterprise developments at a fast pace

Among other sections, enterprises have started sharpening their focus on open source adoption. This will help India reach the next level of growth. "In the past, you had to start developing a new idea from scratch. Nowadays, you can get a headstart by leveraging open source tools and frameworks. This creates a new business reality in which India can play a great role," says Lowagie.

Basu of TechYugadi hopes the special venture capitalist (VC) support will encourage more startups towards open

source solutions. "We will soon see VC support for open source adoption cases, as in the Silicon Valley, to advance the existing community culture," he says.

Airtel's Kumar considers open source technology as the great saviour for enterprises, which helps them achieve their goals at a much lower cost than proprietary solutions. This is a significant reason for entrepreneurs in the country to opt for open source today. "The open source ecosystem has evolved as many companies have started giving enterprise support to open source technologies like MongoDB, Neo4j, Orient and MariaDB, among others," Kumar says.

In April 2015, the Modi-led government launched the much awaited Open Source Policy to boost community solutions in the country. The policy mandates that state-run departments have to use open source for their software applications and services. And it encourages Indian developers who are building native solutions.

"Many projects are already in the process of adopting home-grown open source solutions like Bharat Operating System Solution (BOSS). The government is on the right path, and its Digital India initiative and the Open Source Policy will strengthen open source adoption in the coming years," says Naiya.

Training is the need of the hour

A comprehensive training model for participating in community solutions is imperative to take India's IT growth to the next phase. "For India to become a leader, its collective global systems integrator ecosystem must continue to focus on training and enablement," says Aitken.

The race to get a highly-paid job has so far prevented Indian developers from participating in free open source development and from contributing to the community. But this is likely to be addressed with the adoption of some innovative approaches. "High competition amongst youth for employment was a major reason for low participation in non-paid open source development in India. However, with the rapidly growing startup culture in India, we have seen a fundamental cultural shift in the last six to eight years," Naiya states.

The present education system in India needs to be upgraded to encourage innovation and contribution habits among the youth. This will ultimately bolster the growth of open source in the country. "Pure and proper development efforts in open source, irrespective of what the demand is, or how much would be paid, is vital for the Indian market," says Prasad.

All in all, it can safely be said that open source is growing in India and will make the domestic market a behemoth even amongst developed open source markets, once issues like better training and greater participation in community solutions are addressed. 

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